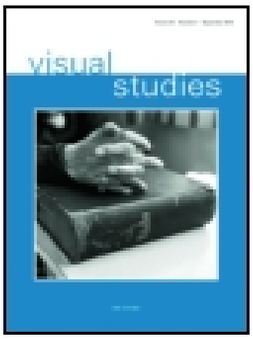

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What Constitutes an Image-based Qualitative Methodology?

Jon Prosser

This paper considers the need for an image-based research methodology. The term 'image-based' is meant to reflect the use of a wide range of visuals, for example, film, video, photographs and cartoons, within a qualitative research context. It is also meant to apply generically to encompass a wide range of fields of study including sociology, anthropology, education and health studies. There are principally two reasons why an image-based methodology is needed: in order to enhance the status and acceptability of image-based research in the wider research community; and to provide a critical platform from which to examine and refine visual methods. A common methodology would improve the status of image-based research in the eyes of orthodox word orientated qualitative researchers and go some way to avoiding damaging divisions within image-based research. The paper explores three areas: How do writers of research methodology view image-based research?; what constitutes a methodological framework?; and some important elements of a visual methodology.

Qualitative researchers live in interesting times. Changes in the global communication and in technology are transforming working practices and leisure activities. With changes in technology and communication systems comes an increase in information. Qualitative researchers do not exist in a vacuum and these changes we see in the wider society are reflected in research strategies, methods, and foci. Innovations such as multi-media, video conferencing, distance learning, computer super highways, virtual reality machines, and digital cameras will alter not only researchers' interests but the ways in which they conduct research. However, image-based researchers and image makers underestimate the increase in text, statistics, interviews, debate and, most importantly, the influence of social organisation and market forces which permeate our society. This means that language, spoken and written will remain pre-eminent. Whilst it can be argued that television, video, computers and film are omnipresent and manifestations of changes in the presentation of visual data, researchers with a visual concern overestimate such influence on and within social research. Language, for example, remains the dominant form of data and method of communicating findings in social research. Walker reflects the frustration of a significant minority of researchers when he states:

> Writing is a more central activity in the social sciences than it is in the sciences, providing us with an apparent escape from the tyranny of empiricism, yet I often feel that we are at a disadvantage in qualitative studies in being constrained by language itself (1994, 72).

This paper assumes that language has primacy in social research and is predominant, and that image-based research can contribute positively to the qualitative research process. Therefore, the central aim of here is not to outline a definitive image-based research model but to discuss issues central to an appropriate methodology. Why do we need such a methodology? There are principally two reasons why this question needs to be asked: in order to enhance the status and acceptability of image-based research in the wider research community; to provide a platform from which to demonstrate how image-based research can make positive and substantial contributions to qualitative research; and as a framework within which a debate concerning the strengths, weaknesses, and potential of image-based research may take place.

Visual sociologists may oppose such an overt political strategy as a formalisation of a

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"visual methodology." It may be argued that image-based research has developed its own eclectic approach but there are dangers in adopting this stance. It should be remembered that early sociologists also adopted a particular "scientific" epistemology which limited interpretative social enquiry for many decades. Image-based research will be devalued and have limited application if we adopt a narrow research paradigm. In addition there is the danger creating a divide between image-based and qualitative research similar to the quantitative-qualitative one in the 1960s and 70s that was so damaging to research design. McNeil reflects on that period:

> Sociologists seemed to spend as much time and effort arguing about how they should be thinking about and studying the social world as they did in actually doing research. These disputes were once described as "British sociology's wars of religion" (1990, 6).

No doubt qualitative researchers do not view image-based research as a threat to the same extent, but the adoption of the principles of qualitative enquiry will avoid a "schism" and strengthen its legitimacy. If image-based research is to be developed and refined, if it is to gain status and acceptability in the eyes of the "traditional" qualitative research community, then a logical starting point is to reflect on generally agreed methodological principles.

It is not possible within this short paper to encompass all image-based research from documentary film to traditional word-based research which uses illustration in a final report. If anything the focus will be on the "middle ground" where both image and language are applied. The discussion will be limited to the consideration of three key areas: *How do writers of research methodology view image-based research?; what constitutes a methodological framework?; and important elements of a visual methodology.*

How do Writers of Research Methodology View Image-Based Research?

Methodological textbooks all too often treat images with scant regard if at all. Highly regarded texts in the UK, frequently read by research students devote a small percentage of their total space to the discussion of photography, video or film in research either in terms of theory or practice. Silverman (1993) for example (although he is clearly interested in the topic) allocates 0.5%, Burgess (1984) 0.25%, Patton (1990) 0.2 %, and Yin (1994) 0.1 %. However, Bogdan and Biklen (1982) discuss the potential of images and allocate ten pages (4.5%) to topics including found photographs, researcher produced-photographs, photographs as analysis, technique and equipment, and what is more, they illustrate their work with four photographs. Nevertheless, it is rare in texts that images are mentioned and where they are it is their weaknesses rather than strengths that is the common denominator.

Many commentators on research methodology perceive image-making as being inappropriate to research. Burgess, for example, states that ." . . there are problems concerning authenticity, availability, sampling, interpretation and presentation" (1984, 140). There is a general belief that images are unacceptable as a way of objectively "knowing" because they distort that which they claim to illuminate. They believe the act of image making; of aiming, framing, manipulating light and camera angle, unacceptably alter the object in the frame and the subjective meaning behind the image. What is a particularly disappointing feature of the most able writers on methodology in the UK is that they *unwittingly* do disservice to image-based research. Some writers begin with light praise for visual data before undermining its potential. Silverman, for example, follows this formula by stating that "images are another neglected source of data for field research" followed by, "the analysis of images raises complex methodological and theoretical issues . . . Moreover, the theoretical basis for the analysis of images is complex" (1993, 70). But at least Silverman explores the "good and bad reasons for the neglect" of the use of visual images in research thereby fueling academic debate, which is not the case of his contemporaries.

While it is recognised that strengths and weaknesses of all research methods should be discussed one is left with the view that a balance

has not been achieved in terms of visual sociology - indeed a darker, nullifying picture, is the norm. It is especially discouraging that methodologists who are most able to suggest ways forward in the adoption of an image-based approach in research and hence overcoming theoretical problems, are not more forthcoming.

There is a case for mapping out the adoption of image-based research within particular fields of enquiry or research strategy. Without a survey of the extent and the manner of adoption of images in different fields of study such as sociology, anthropology, history, health studies, and education, it will be difficult either to learn from multiple experiences or establish agreed methodological principles. We may know what is happening in our visual "pond" but what is happening elsewhere? It is a problem that differing fields of qualitative enquiry are treated as though they were discrete. A benefit of devising an image-based methodology would be that it serves as a platform on which to examine and exchange ideas across different specialities on problematic and innovative practices.

Clearly, qualitative research is dominated by language and image-based research is not high on the agenda. If image-based research is to make inroads into the dominance of language we need to justify their inclusion. The title of this paper is, of course, a nonsense, since a purely image-based approach to research is not possible and that a combination of images and language is a necessity. This reflects the reality of the research enterprise and, given the strong traditions in research theory, recognises that any proposed framework which is wholly eclectic would probably have limited impact. In devising a "visual" methodology applicable to photography, video, film or visual documents, where appropriate we should adopt accepted research practice and where inappropriate develop our own. Only in this way, by accepting the basic tenets of qualitative methodology and combining them with the strengths of an image-based approach, will image-based research gain "currency" within the academic community.

What Constitutes a Methodological Framework?

Methodology itself is not fixed and methodological issues are in a constant state of flux. Qualitative approaches have re-emerged from the shadows of statistical traditions and are no longer seen as the impoverished bed fellow of "proper" research. With this change comes a refreshing re-evaluation amongst the research community of what constitutes an acceptable methodology. In the past proponents of the positivist paradigm have used its traditional cornerstones of validity, reliability, objectivity, and generalisability as a premise to assesses the worth of the qualitative paradigm and, as one would expect, arrived at notions of "too subjective," "too unreliable," and "insufficiently generalizable." The quantitative/qualitative debate has lost is cutting edge. Polarization reflected in the term *quantitative/qualitative watershed* is less discernible now, for as Miles and Huberman explain, practices have and are changing:

More and more "quantitative" methodologists, operating from a logical positivist stance, are using naturalistic and phenomenological approaches to complement tests, surveys, and structured interviews. On the other side, an increasing number of qualitative researchers are using redesigned conceptual frameworks and prestructured instrumentation, especially when dealing with more than one institution or community. Few logical positivists will now dispute the validity and explanatory importance of subjective data, and few phenomenologists still practice pure hermeneutics . . . (1984, 20)

Perhaps this is because qualitative researchers have gained sufficient confidence in their approach to question the appropriateness of narrow notions of validity, reliability etc, and have established interpretations of these terms more in fitting with their research questions. The time is right for qualitative researchers to make changes themselves and recognise the worth of an image-based approach. The construction of a methodology for image-based research for sociologists is particularly imperative as Becker explains:

> Visual sociology . . . is almost completely a creature of professional sociology, an academic discipline, and a poor relation of visual anthropology (Collier and Collier, 1986), which has a somewhat cosier relation

> to its parent discipline; in the anthropological tradition, which required investigators going to far off places to gather skulls and linguistic texts, and dig up archaeological materials as well as gather conventional ethnographic materials, making photographs was just one more obligation of fieldwork. Since visual imagery has not been conventional in sociology since its beginnings, when it was more tied to social reform, most sociologists not only do not accept that obligation, they see few legitimate uses for visual materials, other than as "teaching aids." It is as though using photographs and films in a research report constituted pandering to the low tastes of the public or trying to persuade readers to accept shaky conclusions by using illegitimate "rhetorical" means. In short, using visual materials seems "unscientific," probably because "science" in sociology came to be defined as being objective and neutral, just the opposite of the crusading spirit which animated the early muckraking work, itself intimately tied to *photography (Becker, 1995, 7).

*Sociology and photography are about the same "age," yet there is very little overlap between them. Most qualitative researchers are "word masters" by profession whereas the small number of active image-based researchers have no formal training and draw on their "amateur" experiences outside of research. If images are to be accepted by the orthodox research community then there is a need to overcome built in prejudices and adapt, where possible, to fit the methodological "norm."

Of course the question posed "*What constitutes a methodological framework?*" is a masochist's charter, since any attempt to answer the question, due to competing epistemological premises from "born again positivists" on the one hand and "new ethnographers" on the other, is doomed. However, I will propose a short list and use it purely as a basis for reflection and as a focal point for discussion. The list is based on a combination of theoretical and practical issues which would be addressed by any qualitative study either in a research proposal or in the methodological section of a final report:

Introduction

Statement of the problem

Purpose of the study

Significance of the study

The role of the researcher

Grand tour of key questions

Research Design

Rationale for a qualitative approach

Research strategy

Data collection techniques and recording of data

Data analysis procedure

Methods of verification and approaches to reflexivity

Ethical issues

Outcomes

How are the above issues and findings to be communicated and disseminated?

If image-based research is to gain in status and an increase in application then practitioners will need to take account of the above. Clearly there will be a difference in adoption depending on the aims of the study, the research questions, and the skills and interests of the researcher. Anthropological film makers, for example, may emphasise the communication of knowledge but *if* they wish researchers to perceive their work as "research" then they need to take heed of the list above and make explicit statements in their work. I think it was Krishnamurti who said "If you want to change the world you first have to change yourself." This may apply to image-based researchers since the first step in convincing others of the worthwhileness of "visuals" is to convince ourselves.

What Constitutes a Visual Methodology?

Apart from convincing ourselves of the legitimacy of images what do *we* need to do? Thought needs to be given to how images could be used not only as a method but as an integral part of the research process. Traditionally images have been used sparsely in qualitative research and mainly to relieve the boredom of

the written text, as a way of recording data, to illustrate or describe. If image-based research is to attain its full potential it must go beyond being an adjunct of a larger language based "script." We need to establish a visual methodology which stresses a framework which directs and informs image based research (I am using "methodology" to mean a general or overarching approach to understanding research issues and "method" to designate a specific research technique). Finally, we need to achieve consensus and make *explicit* our rationale for using images and our application of an image-based approach in the research enterprise. I see seven features as central to a visual methodology: *Words and images, frameworks and contexts; data collection; the recording of data; interpreting images; ethics; and the research report.*

Words and Images

Images require support from other forms of evidence and other forms of communication. This is not to suggest that images are used simply as a visual language which bear the hallmarks (and limitations) of written and spoken language. It is to recognise that in a research context it is not acceptable to adopt an "artistic" stance such as that taken by Brett Weston who said:

This verbal gobbledy-gook just bores the hell out of me . . . It might excite certain pseudo-intellectuals but it doesn't excite me. All this art talk on painting and photography is a pile of horseshit (Danziger and Conrad 1984, 168).

There is a dynamic relationship between words and images. Edward Weston discussing this relationship (in this instance between photographs and titles) said " . . . a poet can write a few words under it which will change how you see it. In this case words and picture will affect each other, they enlarge each other" (Ibid., 30).

Given that images without words are not acceptable to the research community there is a need for each image-based researcher to decide how far along the word-image and public-academic continuum their study will be cited. Consideration needs to be given to both the structure of the report (representation) and the manner and extent to which images are used in a study (application). Collier and Collier recognised the gap between ethnographic film and film for research and wearing of academic/non-academic "hats," when they wrote:

When anthropologists become filmmakers they enthusiastically leave inhibiting research strictures behind and produce films that are far more artistic than scientific. This can be dynamic, provided cultural authenticity is retained. In the early flowering of cultural narration films, the concept of what constitute *ethnographic* film was undefined. Visual narration offered anthropologists more license than did the verbal treatises; if they wrote papers with the loose structure of much popular ethnographic film, they could be attacked in the scientific journals. (Collier and Collier 1986, 151)

Frameworks and Contexts

An underpinning theoretical framework guides the research process. Within the qualitative approach there is a wide range of disciplines such as sociology, history and anthropology, and an array of perspectives used including ethnography, ethnomethodology, symbolic interactionism, and phenomenology. Each, in different ways, supports researchers by helping them to order and make sense of the world. Working within a particular discipline or adopting a theoretical framework will hinder or help image-based researchers. If, for example, an image-based researcher works within anthropology which has a history of using images, then the path is eased. On the other hand, visual sociologists are less favoured since sociology lacks a history of image application (unless ethnography were employed which draws heavily on anthropological practice and therefore acquires a degree of acceptability or kudos). There are theoretical parallels in film making and photography since strong traditions exist but these are not directly or easily translatable to the purposes of research. This suggests that certain frameworks set the parameters of acceptability as far as images are concerned.

There is a broad context in which all images are set. National cultures are shifting and whilst there are similarities between them

there are also differences: digital photography gives us pigs with wings and giraffes in outer space which reflects the similarities; British pornography essentially employs film and photographs yet Danish pornography has a substantial cartoon and comic following reflecting the differences. In addition, time, timing and place are important. Images tend to be ambiguous and need context to give them meaning. These broader notions of context and how they impinge on image making and interpretation are explored more fully by Becker (1995) and Chaplin (1994). This suggests that context is all important to the interpretation and meaning we give to images and therefore a cornerstone of any visual methodology.

Data Collection

Throughout this and other phases of the research process image-based researchers (and particularly image-based researchers) are required to be explicit about the criteria and procedures which have informed those decisions. This is not out of any notion of "pure" research or what is evidently good practice, but out of the need to make key decisions transparent to further the acceptance of image-based research in the eyes of language-based qualitative researchers.

In order to be able to collect data from a range of sites, situations and events, and to obtain "naturalistic" data, it is normal to adopt a participant observer role. Accessing people, places and events needs careful consideration, especially for those with, for example, photographic intentions. Traditional qualitative researchers would argue that when photographs/video/film are taken in a research context the act of taking pictures causes intrusion, effects rapport and is therefore seen as leading to negative procedural reactivity. Whilst there is logic to this argument this is not necessarily the case. It could be argued that traditional researchers hold a biased view which has no real basis and perhaps they could learn from the everyday practice of photographers who routinely take ethnographic images. Take, for example, the practice of three National Geographic photographers:

Dudley Brooks: I have always felt that to make great photographs of people, you must first allow the subjects to feel comfortable with your presence.

Dick Swanson: I never sneak pictures. I listen and watch and pick up the vibes. I like the luxury of having the time to let people know me without a camera.

Stuart Franklin: I do not rush people or my photography. I try to give as much time as possible for people to get used to me being there. Then I gradually start taking photographs (*Popular Photography* 1995, 68).

This suggests that ethnographic and documentary photographers place great store in participant observation and taking naturalistic images. Some researchers take photographs on the first day in the field and use them as "can openers" (Collier & Collier, 1986) while I have adopted a gentler strategy: "I began to walk about the school with a camera in its case . . ." then "the camera in its "out of the case over the shoulder like a piece of jewellery" mode" followed by "photographs taken in phase one were "safe" in that they were unlikely to offend participants, or "positive" in that they were useful/beneficial to the school" (Prosser 1992, 398). Whatever approach is taken, the image-based researcher will need to be sensitive to participants concerns and negotiate access to each sampling site.

As a data collection technique, an image-based approach is broadly accepted by the research community. Bogdan & Biklen (1982) differentiate between "found photographs" and "researcher produced photographs." It is easy to recognise that found images could be useful in backward mapping to explore the past. But there are problems with found images. We often lack important information - what was the social context of taking the photograph i.e. the relationship between the image-maker and the subject? What was the purpose and intent of the image? And, as Andrew points out, why do some images survive when others do not?

Documents have differential survival rates and those which do survive do not always provide all the information required . . . The

answers to a great many questions are simply not available, since the necessary records either never existed or failed to survive (Andrew 1985, 156).

These questions should be borne in mind and the limitations of each image considered when analysing found or historical images. We can learn much from visual anthropologists who are aware of these problems, confront them on a daily basis, and strive to overcome their limitations.

Researcher generated images offer a wide range of applications. Bogdan & Biklen suggest that "photos taken by researchers or chosen by researchers and shown to subjects can be used as a stimulant for data gathering" (1982, 109) and Walker and Weidel (1985), Harper (1988) and Prosser (1992), have all described ways of using photographs in an interview situation either to elicit responses on complex issues or to identify the range of participants" attitudes and beliefs. Minor White's comment: "To think of photography as some degree of glorified Rorschach test is not detrimental to either medium" (Danziger and Conrad 1984, 30) reflects the ambiguous nature of images which can be used to advantage in an interview situation and used in a "projective" sense can "trigger" unexpected but valuable comments from interviewees.

Recording of Data

The ability of the camera to record detail accurately without tiring can be used to advantage. Images as cultural inventories (Collier and Collier, 1986) can provide records of events and places which allow the researcher the luxury of leisurely but careful consideration in minutia which may provide an insight into relationships and activities. A camera can be used simply to record non-verbal events or behaviours. In this sense images have a proxemic value (information defining spatial relationships between participants or between participants and objects) or kinesic value (information concerning gestures or postures of participants). Equally, they can be used to supplement observation field notes or tape recordings, as a complete visual record, or to stimulate our memory of events. Camera technology means that a wide variety and a significant volume of images can be recorded but of course caution is needed since there is a distinct possibility of an age-old problem - data overload.

Interpreting Images

So far the use of images and image-making in the research enterprise has been relatively uncontroversial. The use to which images are put, the quality of evidence inherent in an image, and the analysis of images, all constitute more controversial aspects. Interpreting an image in terms of its *quality* as evidence and *meaning* attributable to it are the prime concerns of orthodox qualitative researchers. Of course analysis is a continual process and it is important that it is seen to be a transparent one. Decisions, such as sampling and how data were organised and verified, are part and parcel of this exercise. To some extent a reflexive diary with descriptive, methodological and analytic notes, the adoption of a coding system, which were supplemented with a negative file, contact sheet and background notes, is good practice and would go some way to pacify traditionalists. But for the image-based researcher there are no easy resolutions as Becker, referring to orthodox sociologist's probable rejection of Frank's *The Americans* as a work of scientific sociology, explains:

> They would assume, correctly, that photographs are easily manipulated; the sophisticated ones would know that you need not alter the actual image, just frame the elements properly and wait for an opportune moment. They would worry, properly, about using one image as a surrogate for a larger universe of similar situations. They would not be sure, and have warrant for their uneasiness, that the images have meaning I am inputting. They would not, however, take the next step, which would be to see that every form of social science data has exactly these problems, and that none of the commonly accepted and widely-used sociological methods solves them either (1995, 9).

So, in addition to sociologist's perceiving images as part of vernacular culture, as "down there with the family and holiday snaps," they subject images to a critique they seldom address in a significant way of their own work (I

include myself in the latter group, aware of the ease with which the "taken-for-granted" and rational approaches to enquiry methods which are accepted by the vast majority, roll off my pen). It is of concern that image-based researchers, in an effort to gain acceptance to "real" sociology, will hide their difficulties behind a whole gamut of methodological platitudes. There is an urgency to improve and refine our image-based strategies by recognising and airing our mock-ups and cock-ups. The subsequent problems and repercussions arising from the lack of acceptance of images in a research context are described by Walker: "One of the consequences of the systematic exclusion of photography form the social sciences is that, when we do encounter photographs, we are at a loss with what to do with them" (1990). Any visual methodology would need to face up to these problems.

In order to assess the limitations or strengths of a piece of research understanding how a mass of raw data is reduced to the findings in a slim report is crucial. Non-image based qualitative research has a range of strategies to generate ideas and theory from data expressed in such phrases as "progressive focusing," "codes and categories," "theoretical framework," and "inductive analysis." Image-based researchers, that is researchers who use images *as data* as well as for collecting and recording data, have used this approach in the analysis of photographs, film and video (but see Ball and Smith, 1992 for further analytical approaches). By the time images are to be interpreted the researcher will be some way down the analytical "road" by deciding on the focus of the study, a series of research questions and probably a theoretical framework to guide their thinking. For example, by employing an ethnographic stance and using photographs as cultural inventories Collier devised a set of categories which could be applied to images of interiors from various cultures. He proposed that a visual inventory:

> . . . not only deals with the material content, it also records the arrangement and the use of space. The spatial configuration of otherwise ordinary objects, common to a mass society, may often reflect or express the cultural patterns and values of distinct cultural groups or may provide an insight into the well being of the inhabitants. (Collier & Collier 1986, 47).

Collier used this skeleton framework to ask a series of questions of cultural inventories: What is the economic level?; what is the style?; what is the aesthetic of the decor?; what are the activities of the household?; what is the character of order?; and what are the signs of hospitality and relaxation? The questions could be tailored or altered to suite different research questions and form categories by which to analyse the cultural inventories.

A recurring theme in analysis of images is the difficulty of "decoding" them into words, usually text. In the example given above Collier is transcribing the content of an image. Silverman, however, points out that there is an alternative theoretical basis for the analysis of images:

> It is sometimes argued that attention to the image alone can detract attention from the social processes involved in image-production and image-reception. For instance Slater (1989) argues that semiotic analysis of advertisements has neglected the way in which such images are shaped by the economics logic and social organisation of the relationship between advertising agencies and their clients. A similar argument lies behind the switch of film analysis in the 1980s away from semiotics of film and towards understanding the logic of movie-production in terms of such structures as the studio system (1993, 70).

Mostly people do not "see" they "perceive" and perhaps a key issue is how reflexive researchers are of the images they produce and how do they perceive other(s) images. Image-based research can adapt other analytical models but images are not words and the significance of context, colour, motion, timing and context etc., which are particularly important to images, need to be taken account of and built into the analytical equation.

Ethics

Images and ethics are not good "bedfellows," and ethical considerations are often not given a high priority, as is demonstrated by the British

press on a weekly basis. When an image-maker joins the ranks of researchers the act of making an image and the use to which the image is put should be governed by an ethical code of practice. Whilst professional bodies representing the research community have such a code image based researchers (in the UK at least) do not.

Images are capable of carrying powerful and possibly sensitive messages. Following a research project what happens to the images is important since taken out of context they could damage a participant's standing, affect their career or personal lives. Because cameras are so common and the "snapping" of pictures almost a democratic right in western society the notion of an agreed code of practice may seem alien, or at least disconcerting.

But what sort of code of practice is appropriate? Should there be a contract between, for example, a researcher and a researched and if so should it apply differentially to some (because they have power) and not others (who have little power)? Is the use of a telephoto lens over 300mm an invasion of privacy, and is it acceptable to use filters and wide angle lenses (or cartoons, paintings and graffiti) which, by their nature, distort? These and many other ethical issues need to be addressed if image-based research is to gain acceptance by the research community and those who agree to take part in research.

The Research Report

There are conventions for academic papers and theses but these rarely take into account the use of images. The number of photographs and the way they are used in a research report will vary considerably. Image-based researchers who seek acceptance of their work by non image-based workers either recognise that they need to conform to convention or plough their own "furrow." Even those who accept convention will have to resolve a range of problems and make difficult decisions. Images used in a research sense are ambiguous and need to be given meaning and context with words. But then we return to an earlier question - what is the nature or relationship between words and images? Should image-based researchers include a section in the report suggesting to the reader how to "read" the images? There are so many difficult questions about representation of images as data, ideas or findings (see Chaplin, 1994). Let us consider the case of photographs. They can be used in different ways in a research report, for example, as *illustration*, as *data*, or to *exemplify findings*.

As *illustration* the use of photographs has gained acceptance but are not used to their full potential. A photograph as illustration has face validity which enables the "reader" to check their interpretation with that of the researchers. However, they work best used within certain defined parameters which determine their limitations. In the past photographers, for example Sander (1977), have developed what can be described as "objective photography." They used standard lenses, without filters, emphasising frontality of the subject and flatness of space, taking people in their natural environment, and printing the negative full frame. Used in this way photographs are a window on the world and communicate in a way that words and text cannot.

As *data* the use of photographs is more contentious. They account for fractions of a second, a thin slice of time in the research endeavour, and need to be justified and given meaning. Photographs as data are weak and need to be contrasted with other sorts of data - how is this tension to be discussed in the final report? Another issue is the extent to which artistic licence which gives an image impact and therefore stimulates the "reader" should be used. Finally, what constitutes acceptable data for inclusion in a final report? Is, for example, a "reconstruction" of an event, a practice common in police investigation and documentary work, acceptable as data? These and many more questions need resolutions.

To Exemplify Findings

It is usual that observations and images are translated into text or tables which contributes to findings in a research report. Findings are expressed in ideas, concepts or theories but almost always using words. One potentially

fruitful avenue worthy of consideration by image-based researchers is to translate or illustrate findings using images. This may be disconcerting initially because it will mean clarifying our abstract thoughts sufficiently to identify or create a visual example. Film-makers and photographers find this process quite natural. The inclination to use a photograph to state "this is what I mean by . . ." does not come easy since it makes the findings more public and the researcher more accountable. One way of generating photographs which encapsulate concepts is to draw on the strategies of well known photographers (Prosser 1992, 407).

Summary

The research process and the topics of research are changing as they reflect changes in global communication and increased knowledge. Even though text and the spoken work dominate orthodox qualitative research image-based research can play an increasingly important role. Non image-based researchers and the writers of methodological texts place little value on visual data. If film, video, photography and cartoons are to become more prominent a "visual methodology" needs to be established. Even though research methodology is in a state of flux and more pliable than ever before it is clear that image-based researchers should consider, initially at least, working within a framework that is acceptable to the research community. This paper has outlined some elements of a visual methodology and, of course, they were discussed too briefly and superficially to do them justice. However, in the future as each element is explored more fully a holistic view, encompassed by the term "visual methodology," will be more attainable.

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